But if in 2012, Modi did not even campaign in UP because of personal vendetta, he could not afford to think even remotely of any such move in 2014. Now, he needed to desperately turn around the BJP's fortunes in the state to achieve his prime ministerial ambition. And this time, he needed someone by his side who he could implicitly trust. There was only one such man in Modi's eyes.

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The first time I met Amit Shah, the circumstances were rather unenviable, to say the least. I was covering the highly surcharged Gujarat 2002 assembly election campaign being held in the backdrop of the riots. My travels had brought me to Sarkhej on the outskirts of Ahmedabad where Shah was standing for re-election. Advani, who was the MP from Gandhinagar which encompassed the Sarkhej area, was to address a rally. I was attempting a live link with our Delhi studio when suddenly the crowd encircled me. *'Arre, yeh wahi Rajdeep Sardesai hai jisne Gujarat dangon mein hamare khilaaf prachar kiya. Isko hum nahin chodenge'* (This is the same Rajdeep who campaigned against us during the Gujarat riots. We must not let him get away). The next thing I knew I was being pushed and kicked by Shah supporters wearing saffron bandanas. A kind police officer stepped in and had to whisk us away to safety.

When the rally was over, I met Shah to complain. 'What kind of behaviour is this, sir? You must rein in your supporters,' I told him. He was duly apologetic. *'Yeh galat hai, mein iski ninda karta hoon. Mein kabhi hinsa ke paksh mein nahi hoon'* (This is wrong, I condemn it. I would never support any kind of violence). And then, he smiled and delivered a parting shot, *'Rajdeepji, aapko bhi thoda apna khyal rakhna chahiye'* (You should also be careful). The words were said in a soft and gentle manner, but the underlying message, I feared, was a little more harsh.

That was then. In the decade that followed, much had changed in my life but also, more importantly, in the life of Shah. Then, he was seen as the local dada of Sarkhej, someone who enjoyed the unquestioned support of